

Trans-composition

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Figure 1: Screenshot of the Trans-composition VR Experience.

Abstract

Trans-composition is a poetic, immersive VR experience that explores personal transformation through the metaphors of the Chinese game of Go and Taoist philosophy. Participants enter a meta-physical “house of life,” composed of symbolic rooms representing stages of existence and shifting states of perception. The architecture of this space embodies duality, black and white, light and shadow, self and other, yet reveals their subtle interconnection. Interaction unfolds through the embodied act of placing stones on the Go board, where each contemplative move triggers a transformation of the environment, reflecting moments in life’s unfolding journey. Within this meditative exploration, participants gradually discover that the game they are playing is ultimately with themselves. They are simultaneously player and piece, architect and

inhabitant, navigating a circular narrative where every ending carries the seed of a new beginning. Rather than providing answers, the work invites participants to compose their own meaning, a space for reflection where ancient philosophy converges with immersive technology, offering a quiet dialogue on perception, duality, and self-awareness.

CCS Concepts

• Human-centered computing; • Virtual reality; • Interaction design; • Applied computing; • Media arts;

Keywords

Virtual reality, Embodied Interaction, Cultural Aesthetics, Go, Duality, Metaphorical Design

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1 INTERACTIVE NARRATIVE AND EXPERIENTIAL DESIGN

Trans-composition employs a first-person narrative structure, using internal monologue to anchor the participant's perspective within the diegetic world. This immersive strategy enhances embodiment by aligning the user's movement through space with a subjective voice, a reflective narration that evokes memory, doubt, and insight (Ryan, 2001). Each symbolic room is encountered as an extension of the self, not merely observed but inhabited. In VR, Trans-composition prioritizes lived experience, turning the participant from a passive viewer into an active author (Bucher, 2018; Frey, 2014). The environment becomes a direct and evolving reflection of the participant's journey, where each space remains as a visible record of the "game" played. Every movement and every choice thus becomes a meaningful act of narrative composition.

At the heart of interaction is a single embodied act: placing a Go stone. Quiet and deliberate, this gesture begins a transformation, linking past choices with changing space and emotion. Along the way, participants encounter a straightedge and compass, tools that symbolize order and freedom. These objects invite reflection on how structure and autonomy shape the self. They are not decorative, but embedded in the narrative logic. Following Ryan's notion of narrative-within-interaction (Ryan, 2001), the Go stone, symbolic tools, and player agency become carriers of meaning. Interaction becomes an introspective act, where constraint and freedom co-author the self in motion.

In the final space, interaction turns inward. From the elevated vantage point of old age, participants witness the entire life pattern they have shaped. The final interaction becomes an emotional confrontation between memory and self. Through this design, Trans-composition transforms interaction into introspection, laying the groundwork for a deeper phenomenological inquiry.

2 THEORETICAL FRAMEWORKS: EMBODIED PERCEPTION

The project's design is grounded in phenomenological and pragmatist theories of experience, with a particular focus on Maurice Merleau-Ponty's concept of the "body-subject". Merleau-Ponty posits that existence is fundamentally a corporeal experience; all perception is fundamentally embodied (Merleau-Ponty, 1962). Trans-composition leverages VR to transcend passive observation and evoke a new form of embodied poetry.

In this work, the virtual body is a primary vehicle of understanding. The physical act of reaching, grasping, and placing a Go stone is not simply an input method; it is an instance of embodied cognition, where meaning arises from lived, intentional action. This aligns with the pragmatist philosophy of experience, which emphasizes that meaning and emotion are generated from the sensory qualities of our actions and interactions (McCarthy and Wright, 2004). VR's immersive quality enables the full realization of perceptual subject-consciousness (Grau, 2004). The participant's interaction with the virtual Go stone feels as though it occurs in a "real space," creating a powerful link between their physical action and the narrative transformation it triggers (Heim, 1993). This integration creates a dynamic authorship where life's 'poem' is co-composed by design, embodied choices, and the digital world's responses.

3 AESTHETICS AND CULTURAL SYNTHESIS

The experience's transformative power emerges from a synthesis of metaphorical design, spatial symbolism, and the core mechanic of "Trans-composition." The environment is saturated with symbolic meaning, from the Go grid that underlies each space to the Chinese knots embedded in the architecture, expressing the interwoven nature of freedom and destiny. The visual language is grounded in classical Chinese aesthetics, where space and perception are not shown directly but suggested and intuited. The architectural structure draws from the compositional logic of ink wash painting, with its non-linear, layered perspectives that invite contemplation. Meaning arises through implication, a grammar of absence, ambiguity, and atmospheric depth. This principle shapes the spatial choreography of the experience: architecture resists linearity, favoring recursive, meandering paths where meaning unfolds gradually as a quiet traversal of inner states. In parallel, paper-cutting, formed both in structure and through light, articulates a dialectic of presence and absence, where form emerges as much from removal as from construction. Negative space holds meaning: absence becomes form. Rendered in real time, this aesthetic allows light and shadow to respond to the participant's presence. Here, visibility transcends surface and becomes metaphysical, tracing the arc of inner transformation. In the final stage, the participant returns to a space that appears familiar, yet subtly reconfigured by the journey, a quiet return. This cyclical closure resonates with the Taoist principle of transformation within continuity, where opposites do not resolve into synthesis, but flow in coexistence. Ultimately, Trans-composition does not use XR to simulate reality, but to stage a living metaphor, a contemplative dialogue between self and fate, where each contemplative gesture, like each Go stone, composes the poetry of a life.

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